



INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD

Whistleblowing Policy

2023



IFDC 

1. Introduction

At the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC), we are unwavering in our commitment to uphold the highest standards of ethics, integrity, and transparency in all our endeavors. Our core mission is to champion child rights, ensure digital safety for children, promote a healthy digital balance, and advocate for the responsible use of all digital tools. We firmly believe that fostering an environment of trust and accountability is not only fundamental to our mission but also critical in safeguarding and empowering children in the digital age.

To reaffirm these principles, IFDC has established a Whistleblower Policy. This policy is meticulously crafted to inspire and empower all our employees, volunteers, contractors, and stakeholders to promptly report any concerns or suspicions they may have regarding unethical or illegal activities within our organization.

IFDC recognizes that individuals within the organization may become aware of wrongdoing or misconduct that undermines our core values and mission. We firmly believe that addressing these concerns promptly and effectively is imperative for the well-being of our organization, its members, and most importantly, the children we serve.

This Whistleblower Policy provides a clear roadmap for reporting concerns, outlines the safeguards in place to protect whistleblowers, and elucidates the actions that IFDC will take to thoroughly investigate and address reported issues. It is our solemn commitment to ensure that anyone who takes the courageous step of reporting potential wrongdoing is treated with the utmost respect, unwavering confidentiality, and safeguarded against any form of retaliation.

We wholeheartedly encourage all members of the IFDC community to acquaint themselves with this policy and to use it as a powerful tool to uphold our shared dedication to transparency, accountability, and ethical conduct. By doing so, we can collaboratively maintain the highest standards of integrity and continue making a profoundly positive impact in our mission to protect and empower children in the digital world.

2. Scope of the Policy

The core objective of this policy is to establish a robust internal mechanism within IFDC for the reporting, investigation, and rectification of any misconduct. This policy encompasses a broad range of allegations, including but not limited to:

1. Conduct that violates the law or IFDC's policies.
2. Suspected miscarriages of justice.
3. Grave health and safety hazards.
4. Unauthorized utilization of IFDC's or public funds.
5. Potential fraud and corruption.
6. Any form of abuse, including sexual, physical, verbal, bullying, or intimidation.
7. Abuse of authority.
8. Various other forms of unethical conduct, including, but not confined to:
 - Criminal activities.
 - Non-compliance with legal or regulatory obligations.
 - Environmental harm.

- Bribery (under the Anti-Fraud and Corruption Policy).
- Financial fraud or mismanagement.
- Tax evasion.
- Breaches of IFDC's policies and procedures.
- Actions detrimental to IFDC's reputation or financial stability.
- Unauthorized disclosure of confidential information.
- Acts of negligence.
- Discrimination (e.g., based on race or gender).
- Issues concerning manager/employee relations.
- Abuse or misuse of power.
- Fraudulent procurement.
- Concealment of any of the aforementioned wrongful acts.

This policy underscores IFDC's commitment to promoting child rights, ensuring digital safety for children, fostering a healthy digital balance, and advocating for the responsible use of all forms of digital tools.

3. Purpose of the Policy

This policy serves a dual purpose:

1. To provide comprehensive information about whistleblowing, assisting individuals in determining whether their intended action would be protected under whistleblowing legislation.
2. To establish a transparent and confidential process for addressing concerns, ensuring protection against reprisals or victimization.

4. Safeguards

IFDC unequivocally acknowledges that reporting concerns can be a formidable task. We want to emphasize that employees who report in good faith and in the best interests of our organization and, more importantly, the children we serve, should not fear retaliation. IFDC has zero tolerance for any form of harassment or victimization of whistleblowers and is committed to taking immediate and appropriate action to safeguard those who report wrongdoing.

5. Our Commitments

IFDC's commitment is unswerving. We pledge to maintain a culture of openness, honesty, and accountability, where all staff members can confidently report legitimate concerns across all aspects of our operations. We take any manifestation of misconduct with the utmost seriousness and actively encourage our board, staff, and members to be vigilant regarding wrongdoing, urging them to report concerns at the earliest stage possible. We firmly believe that it is preferable for matters to be raised as concerns rather than waiting for incontrovertible proof or individual investigations. Designated individuals will handle each matter with the utmost diligence and impartiality.

6. Procedures for Making a Disclosure

- a. Staff members are encouraged to promptly report any specified actions (past, present, or anticipated) to their immediate supervisor.

- b. In cases where the issue is deemed grave, especially if it relates to potential criminal activities, the immediate supervisor should elevate the matter to the attention of both the Finance, Administration & Human Resources Manager and the Executive Director. These key individuals will then oversee a comprehensive investigation.
- c. If the allegation involves the actions of the immediate supervisor or is of a more serious nature, the employee should direct their report to the Finance, Administration & Human Resources Manager. In instances where the immediate supervisor is the subject of the allegation, the report should be forwarded directly to the Executive Director.
- d. Complaints targeting Board Members or the Executive Director should be directed to the Finance, Administration & Human Resources Manager or the designated Nominated Board Members.
- e. Whistleblowers retain the right to bypass the standard line management structure and report their concerns directly to the Nominated Board Members or the Board Chair.
- f. The Nominated Board Members or the Chair may refer the complaint back to the management team if they believe that management can impartially conduct the investigation.
- g. In the event of allegations involving criminal activity, the designated investigating officer should promptly inform the police. IFDC is committed to ensuring that an internal investigation does not hinder any formal police inquiry.
- h. Whistleblowers have the option to request that their concerns be handled confidentially. This request will be honored, as long as it does not impede the investigation. However, it's important to note that the investigation process may inadvertently reveal the source of the information, and in such cases, the whistleblower may be required to provide a statement as part of the evidence.
- i. IFDC assures staff members that they will not face any adverse consequences for reporting specified actions, and they will receive full protection against reprisals. We strongly encourage all individuals to make use of this procedure if they have concerns about wrongdoing at their workplace.
- j. If an allegation is made in good faith but is not substantiated by a subsequent investigation, no action will be taken against the whistleblower. However, we encourage whistleblowers to exercise due diligence to ensure the accuracy of the information they provide.
- k. If the procedure is invoked in bad faith, such as for malicious reasons or personal grievances, disciplinary action may be initiated, including dismissal, as deemed appropriate based on the circumstances.
- l. While this policy encourages individuals to identify themselves in their disclosures, complete anonymity is also accepted. Concerns expressed anonymously will be considered at the discretion of the organization, with factors such as the gravity of the issues raised, the credibility of the concern, and the likelihood of substantiating the allegation from attributable sources taken into account.

7. Internal Reporting (First Option):

We strongly recommend whistleblowers to initially raise their concerns internally within IFDC, utilizing our internal Whistleblowing policy, and contacting designated individuals. This

approach enables us to proactively address the issue within the organization while upholding our commitment to child rights, digital safety, and ethical conduct.

Contact Responsible IFDC Personnel:

Whistleblowers may report their concerns directly to designated individuals, with particular emphasis on reaching out to the Chairperson of the Board of Directors, via President@ifdchild.org, and Whistleblowing@IFDchild.org.

Alternative Reporting Mechanism:

If whistleblowers prefer or are unable to use IFDC's internal mechanisms, they are encouraged to report their concerns by sending an email to Whistleblowing@IFDchild.org.

8. Confidentiality

IFDC places the utmost importance on maintaining the strictest confidentiality. Every conceivable effort will be made to safeguard the whistleblower's identity unless the whistleblower explicitly requests otherwise.

In the event that an allegation leads to court proceedings, the whistleblower may be required to provide evidence in open court if deemed necessary. Be assured that IFDC will not disclose the whistleblower's identity to anyone without their consent, except when mandated by law or in exceptional circumstances where disclosure is imperative to safeguard child rights, digital safety, and our ethical mission.